KEYNOTE ADDRESS AT THE 38th ANNUAL CONVENTION OF THE CANON LAW SOCIETY OF NIGERIA

Your Lordships, distinguished members of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria, Reverend Fathers, ladies and gentlemen,

Thank you for inviting me to address this 38th Annual Convention – and for considering me worthy of an award conferred on the strength of our modest governance achievements.

An award from a revered institution like the Canon Law Society of Nigeria is indeed a seal of honour.

Yet, I recognize that the true value of public recognition lies in the responsibility it places upon the recipient. So, this award is an encouragement to work harder and to remain steadfast in our commitment to inclusive development.

I'm honoured, too, to be in the presence of a remarkable son of the Church, whose life and work embody the values of service and sacrifice.

I refer, of course, to Most Reverend Anthony Gbuji, Emeritus Bishop of Enugu and founder of the Canon Law Society of Nigeria.

It is gratifying that this occasion also celebrates his 95th birthday anniversary – and fittingly so with a dedicated academic session to honour his legacy.

PAGE 2

I am particularly pleased to be speaking to an audience that has devoted so much thought to the relationship between law, conscience and the responsibilities we owe to one another.

These are questions that concern me deeply as Governor, because every decision we make in public office ultimately touches the life of somebody we may never meet.

A budget allocation can determine whether a child receives a decent education. An appointment can influence the quality of public services for years. The decision to invest in a neglected community can change the prospects of an entire generation.

Behind the machinery of government are human lives.

And the same is true of the Church. Behind its schools, parishes, hospitals and institutions are people who come

seeking knowledge, guidance, care and sometimes simply the means to get through another day.

We are here to consider the “Role of the Church in Shaping Education and Development in Enugu State.”

I believe that question takes us to something fundamental about the kind of society we are trying to build.

Every flourishing society rests upon two foundations.

The first is knowledge: our capacity to understand the world, to solve problems, to innovate, to create wealth and improve the conditions in which people live.

The second is conscience: the judgement that guides how we use those abilities, particularly when our choices affect the lives of others.

A society needs both. Indeed, we have seen what happens when intelligence and technical ability are separated from moral responsibility:

Public resources are mismanaged by people who understand their value; Institutions are weakened by those entrusted with

protecting them; Opportunities that could benefit thousands are captured for the advantage of a few.

These failures should trouble us because they reveal something uncomfortable.

Education, by itself, offers no guarantee that a person will act in the public interest.
We can teach people how to exercise power. We must also help them understand the responsibility that comes with it.

And that is why the relationship between Church and State matters so much to our future.

We share an interest in the development of human capability. We also share responsibility for the values that will govern its use.

PAGE 4

Distinguished Guests, Brothers and Sisters,

The Catholic Church has earned a distinguished place in the educational history of Enugu and Nigeria.

Long before our present educational system took shape, missionaries were establishing schools, training teachers and opening opportunities for families who understood that education could change the course of their children's lives.

Across the former Eastern Region, mission schools became centres of learning and intellectual ambition. Their classrooms helped form generations of teachers, doctors, lawyers, entrepreneurs and public servants. Many of those who contributed to the struggle for independence and the building of Nigeria's early institutions emerged from that educational tradition.

We owe a considerable debt to that inheritance. But its significance extends beyond the number of schools established or the qualifications their students acquired.

There was an understanding that education carried a social obligation.

Knowledge was expected to find expression in service. Personal achievement came with responsibilities to family, community and country. The formation of character belonged within the education of the child.

PAGE 5

Of course, those institutions belonged to their time, and education has changed enormously since then. We should examine their history with clear eyes.

But the principle that animated their best work remains profoundly relevant.
A nation can produce highly accomplished individuals and still fail to build a society in which people flourish together.

The difference lies partly in what those individuals understand their accomplishments to be for. The Church helped establish an educational tradition that recognised this connection between personal development and responsibility to others.

That is an inheritance worth carrying into the future.

Our relationship has travelled a considerable distance since those early mission schools.

There was a time when the Church carried much of the responsibility for formal education.

Government subsequently took over many mission schools, and later came the process of returning institutions to their original proprietors.

Each chapter reflected the priorities and circumstances of its time. Each also left questions about ownership, authority, resources and responsibility.

PAGE 6

We cannot pretend that this history has always been easy. But I believe we now have an opportunity to move the relationship into a more mature phase.

We have spent many years debating who should own and manage schools.
We must now give equal attention to what those schools are capable of achieving, and how the different institutions responsible for them can work together.

The demands upon education have become too great for either institution to rely entirely upon its own resources and traditions.
Government has the responsibility to create an educational system that is accessible, properly funded and capable of meeting national and international standards.

The Church brings generations of educational experience, a tradition of pastoral care, a commitment to moral formation and a relationship with communities that government cannot simply reproduce through legislation or public expenditure.

These strengths are different. Their value becomes greater when they are brought together.

And there is a larger point here. Neither government nor the Church exists for the preservation of its own institutions alone.

Institutions earn their place in society through the lives they improve and the responsibilities they fulfil.

PAGE 7

The question facing us, therefore, is how to make this partnership work for the people of Enugu in the circumstances we face today.

My own understanding of leadership has been deeply influenced by faith. The values I encountered growing up helped shape my sense of responsibility, my understanding of service and the standards by which I try to judge my own conduct.

But I have also learned that values acquire their meaning when they are tested. In public office, those tests are often very practical.

Take the question of appointing somebody to a position of responsibility.

There may be a person you know well, perhaps even a relative, who wants the appointment. You understand their expectations. There may be years of friendship, family loyalty or personal obligation involved.

And then there is another candidate whose qualifications and experience make them better suited to the role.

What do you do in such situation?

For me, the answer must be to choose the person best qualified to serve the State. That decision may come at a personal cost. Somebody may feel disappointed or rejected. A relationship may become strained.

PAGE 8

But the office belongs to the public. Its responsibilities are far greater than the personal interests of the individual making the appointment.

The person appointed will make decisions affecting other people's lives. Their competence, judgement and integrity will have consequences long after the appointment itself has been forgotten.

That is why conscience matters in leadership. It asks us to consider whose interests we are serving, especially when doing the right thing is inconvenient.

And I believe this is something young people learn as much from observation as from instruction.

They notice how adults behave. They see whether the rules apply equally to everyone. They discover whether integrity is a principle we practise or merely something we recommend to others.

We cannot expect the next generation to develop a stronger sense of public responsibility than the example we are prepared to set.

When we came into office, we set an ambitious goal for Enugu: to grow our economy from approximately $4.4 billion to $30 billion.

That ambition reflects our determination to change the economic possibilities available to our people.

PAGE 9

But an economy of that scale cannot be built simply by attracting investment or constructing infrastructure. It requires people with the knowledge, confidence and practical ability to create value.

It requires young people who can participate in modern industries, develop enterprises, adapt to technological change and solve problems that we cannot yet anticipate.

And that requires us to rethink education. In Enugu, we have embarked upon a fundamental transformation of our basic education system through the Smart Green Schools programme.

Our ambition is to give children across the state access to modern learning environments, digital resources and a curriculum that develops practical competence alongside academic knowledge.

We are moving away from an excessive dependence on rote learning towards experiential education.

Let’s consider what that means inside a classroom. Imagine a classroom in Enugu where children are exploring the problem of clean drinking water.

Rather than simply learning the science of water purification from a textbook, the teacher challenges them to find a way of making contaminated water cleaner using materials available in their community.

PAGE 10

The children work in groups. They investigate possible solutions, construct simple filters, test the results and discover why some approaches work better than others. Some of their ideas fail. They have to rethink them. They learn to question their assumptions, listen to one another and improve their designs.

The teacher then asks them to consider how their discoveries might help families in communities where clean water is difficult to obtain.

Suddenly, science, mathematics, creativity and social responsibility come together. The children are learning to apply knowledge to a problem that matters in the world around them.

That, in summary, is the goal of Experiential Learning: to develop young people who can think independently, learn from experience and use their knowledge to improve the world they inhabit.

The teacher thus becomes a guide to inquiry. The child learns to question, explore and make connections.

The same approach can be applied across science, mathematics, technology and other subjects. We want children to leave school with the confidence to use what they have learned.

We also want to expand technical and vocational education, connecting learning more closely to the opportunities emerging in agriculture, manufacturing, technology, aviation, tourism and other areas of our economy.

PAGE 11

And we want a child growing up in a rural community to have access to the kind of education that opens the same

possibilities as those available to a child in the centre of Enugu.

This is an ambitious undertaking. It demands substantial investment, but it also requires a profound change in teaching.

Teachers must learn new methods. They must become comfortable with approaches that may be very different from those through which they themselves were educated.

And that brings me directly to the Church.

Concerns have been raised by the Church about the Smart Green Schools programme. I have been asked whether the scale of our investment in public schools means that Church schools may eventually be left behind.

I understand that concern. These are institutions that have educated generations of our people. Their leaders have every reason to care about their place in Enugu's educational future.

So I want to answer them directly.

The Church is essential to the educational transformation we are undertaking.

PAGE 12

So, it would be deeply counterproductive for government to invest in a new system of learning while allowing Church educators and institutions to become disconnected from it.

We need you in our basic education system. We need your teachers, your experience and your continuing commitment to the development of our children.

And we intend to make that partnership practical. Reverend Fathers are already being brought into the training process, and our intention is that

Church educators should have access to the professional development opportunities being created for teachers in government schools.

As we introduce experiential learning, we want educators across both systems to acquire the knowledge and skills needed to participate.

That is an obligation I believe government should take seriously.

The Church, in turn, has an opportunity to embrace new educational methods while preserving the values and traditions that have distinguished its contribution.

We will have to work through practical questions about training, standards, resources and implementation. Some established practices will need to change.

PAGE 13

But the scale of the opportunity is considerable.

We can bring together modern educational investment and a long tradition of intellectual and moral formation.

We can prepare children to participate confidently in the economy of the future while developing the judgement to use their abilities responsibly.

That is the kind of educational partnership I want us to build.

There is a simple truth that should guide this relationship. The children in our Church schools and the children in our government schools belong to the same communities.

They will grow up in the same society, contribute to the same economy and inherit the consequences of the decisions we make today.

Our institutions may be different. The people we serve are the same. And the needs of those people extend far beyond the classroom.

To illustrate this further, I want you to consider a situation that will be familiar to many priests, particularly those serving in rural communities.

A mother comes to the church with her child. The child is hungry.

PAGE 14

There may be no food at home, or perhaps the family has reached the point where the cost of sending that child to school is simply beyond them.

The mother has come because she trusts the priest. She believes that, whatever her circumstances, somebody here will listen.

The priest looks for what he can spare. Perhaps he finds some food. Perhaps he offers a little money to help the child return to school.

It is a small act of care, but its importance to that family is immense.

Indeed, the priest may know much more about their circumstances than any government official.

He may know what has happened to the parents, how long the family has been struggling, which children have stopped attending school and who else in the community is quietly going without.

The Church knows people in ways that public institutions often do not. It knows the families behind the figures. That knowledge matters enormously.

But I want us to follow this child a little further. The immediate hunger has been relieved. The mother is grateful. The priest has done what he can.

PAGE 15

What happens tomorrow?

The family still needs a reliable means of earning a living. The child needs to attend school regularly and receive an education that offers a genuine chance of advancement.

As that child grows older, there must be opportunities to acquire skills, find employment, build an enterprise and contribute to the community.

The original problem was hunger. But the conditions that produced that hunger reach into the economy, education, employment, healthcare and the opportunities available to the family.

A priest can help a child through a difficult day. Government must help create the conditions in which that child can grow towards a different future.

And neither responsibility can be fully understood in isolation.

This is why I believe the Church has an important role to play in our wider efforts to reduce poverty and expand opportunity.

Its relationships with vulnerable families can help us understand where assistance is most urgently needed and how public programmes might reach people more effectively.

PAGE 16

The Church can also contribute through health education, community support, skills development, mentoring and its continuing work with young people.

Government must fulfill its responsibility through better schools, accessible healthcare, infrastructure, economic development and institutions capable of serving the public fairly and effectively.

The connection between these efforts is what matters. A school can offer a child an excellent education, but that child's prospects are diminished if poverty repeatedly keeps them out of the classroom.

A young person may acquire valuable skills, but those skills will be wasted if the economy provides no opportunity to use them.

A family may work hard to improve its circumstances, only to be pushed back into hardship by illness, insecurity or the absence of essential services.

These are interconnected problems. They require us to think about development as a whole.

And at the centre of that system is a human being whose life is shaped by the quality of the relationships, institutions and opportunities surrounding them.

PAGE 17

If Church and State can bring their strengths together around that person, our partnership will have consequences far beyond the walls of our schools.

There is, however, a difficult question we must confront. If the case for cooperation is so compelling, why do institutions so often struggle to achieve it?

Why do we find it difficult to act upon principles we readily agree with?

I believe part of the answer lies in what we are unwilling to give up. At the personal level, service demands that we sometimes set aside our own advantage.

The public appointment I spoke about earlier is one example. The responsibility of office may require us to disappoint somebody close to us because the interests of the wider community must come first.

That principle is easy to defend in a speech. It becomes much harder when the decision is ours to make.

And it applies equally to the Church and to government. We must examine our attachment to status, influence, personal comfort and the privileges that accompany authority.

We must be prepared to ask whether our decisions genuinely serve the people who depend upon us.

PAGE 18

At the institutional level, the challenge becomes more complicated.

Church and State have different responsibilities, histories and ways of working. There will be disagreements over resources, educational standards, authority and the pace of reform.

There may be occasions when government believes a change is necessary and the Church believes that change threatens something valuable.

Those disagreements deserve serious consideration. But we should also recognise how easily legitimate concerns can become entangled with institutional pride.

We become attached to the familiar. We defend arrangements because they are ours. We may resist a better approach because accepting it would require us to surrender some control.

That is a danger for any institution with a long history or considerable power.

And I believe the test of a mature partnership is whether we can recognise those tendencies in ourselves and still find the courage to act in the wider interest.

The Church must retain the independence that gives its moral voice credibility.

Government must exercise the authority and responsibility entrusted to it by the people. Our differences need not prevent cooperation.

Indeed, a partnership in which both sides can speak honestly, challenge one another and work through disagreement may prove far more valuable than one built upon comfortable assurances.

But there is a third challenge, and it extends beyond the relationship between our institutions.

We are living through a period of extraordinary technological change. Artificial intelligence is already altering how knowledge is produced, how work is organised and how decisions are made.

The capabilities available to the next generation will be far greater than those available to us today. That offers enormous possibilities for education, enterprise, medicine, agriculture and the wider economy.

It also raises profound questions about judgement and responsibility.

The ability to produce information does not guarantee that it is truthful. The power to influence people does not establish the right to manipulate them. Greater technological capability does not necessarily produce greater concern for human welfare.

PAGE 20

These are questions that education must prepare young people to confront. And they return us to the central proposition of this address.

Knowledge expands what human beings are capable of doing. Conscience must guide the purposes to which those capabilities are put. As our power increases, that responsibility becomes more demanding.

The danger is that we become so absorbed in developing the capabilities of the next generation that we neglect the moral intelligence needed to govern them.

Or it may be that in our own institutions, we allow the pursuit of influence, control and material advantage to displace the people we were established to serve.

The greatest threat to our shared ambition may lie in what we are unwilling to surrender for the common good.

That is a challenge I place before myself as Governor. And I offer it to this gathering in the spirit of the honest partnership I believe we must build.

Let us look twenty years ahead.

By then, the children entering our schools today will be adults.

PAGE 21

They will have inherited an Enugu shaped by the investments we make, the institutions we strengthen and the values we demonstrate during these years.

Many will be working in industries and professions that are only beginning to emerge. They will have access to technologies that may transform how they live, learn and earn a living.

We want them to be capable of making the most of those opportunities. We want them to be inventive, ambitious and confident. We want them to create wealth, develop

businesses, advance knowledge and contribute to the prosperity of our state and country.

But I would also want them to look at the society around them and recognise responsibilities that extend beyond their own advancement. I would want them, as well, to understand that the prosperity of a community depends upon the opportunities available to its people.

And to recognise that public authority carries obligations towards those who have little influence or power. To have the courage to make difficult decisions fairly, even when personal interest points in another direction.

These qualities will matter enormously in the Enugu we are trying to build. And they cannot be developed by the school alone.

PAGE 22

That’s because a child's understanding of the world begins in the family.

It is shaped by teachers, religious communities, friendships, the wider society and the conduct of those in authority.

The opportunities available to that child depend upon the strength of our economy, the quality of public institutions, the security of our communities and the choices we make about the distribution of resources.

Education belongs within this larger system of human development. That is why I am asking us to think ambitiously about the future of the relationship between Church and State.

We have an opportunity to create a more deliberate partnership in education, beginning with the training and professional development of Church educators and their participation in the transformation now taking place.

We have an opportunity to strengthen cooperation in identifying and supporting vulnerable families, drawing upon the Church's intimate knowledge of communities and government's responsibility to create wider economic and social opportunity.

And we have an opportunity to demonstrate, through the way our institutions work together, the very qualities of service, integrity and responsibility that we want the next generation to inherit.

PAGE 23

This will require sustained commitment. It will require difficult conversations, practical decisions and a willingness to measure our success against the lives of the people we serve.

I welcome that responsibility. Because when I think about the future of Enugu, I think of the possibilities that should be available to a child born here today:

A child whose family may have very little, but whose abilities and aspirations are no less valuable than those of a child born into comfort.

A child who deserves to discover what they are capable of, and crucially, to develop those abilities and to find a place in a society that has room for their contribution.

The Church has spent generations helping such children find their way. Government now has the opportunity, and the responsibility, to build the conditions in which many more of them can flourish.

We should bring those efforts together with purpose and determination.

And perhaps, twenty years from now, we will be able to look at the generation we have helped raise, and recognise something of the best of both our institutions:

PAGE 24

Our responsibility is to prepare our children for the world they will inherit, and to give them the character, confidence and opportunity to build a better one.

Let us develop people who have the knowledge to shape their world.

Let us nurture our children’s conscience to consider the consequences of their actions, and the courage to take responsibility for the society they share.

Let us build faith, knowledge and character that endure across generations.

That is a future worthy of our shared commitment.

Thank you, and God bless Enugu State.